

Session Imbalance

Indicators & Analysis / Order Flow & Auction | intermediate | 4 min read | DeepCharts Help Center | July 16, 2026

The Session Imbalance indicator highlights the key price levels created in the first hour of trading — or any custom period you define. It plots the Initial Balance High, Initial Balance Low and the Midpoint between them, and can add optional 50% and 100% extension levels above and below the range.

The Initial Balance is a cornerstone of auction-based day trading: the range built during the opening period frames how the rest of the session is read. For the theory behind it, see [Understanding Auction Theory: Imbalance, Unfinished Auctions, Absorption and Understanding Market Structure and Sessions \(RTH/ETH, Rollover\)](#).

What it is

At the start of each session the indicator measures the high and low printed during the configured number of minutes (60 by default) and projects those levels — plus the midpoint — across the rest of the session. Extension levels at 50% and 100% of the Initial Balance range can be projected beyond the high and low, giving you pre-computed targets for breakout days.

When to use it

- To frame the trading day: rotation inside the Initial Balance versus extension beyond it.
- To get ready-made breakout targets (50% and 100% extensions) without manual measuring.
- To study how many recent sessions respected or extended their opening range, by loading multiple days.
- To be alerted when price takes out the Initial Balance extremes or reaches an extension level.

Quick start

1. Add **Session Imbalance** to your chart.
2. Keep **Number of Minutes** at its default of 60 for the classic first-hour Initial Balance.
3. Set **Number of Days (0 - All)** to a small number (for example 5) while you learn the tool — 0 draws every available session and can crowd the chart.
4. Enable the **50%** and **100%** extension levels if you want breakout targets plotted automatically.
5. Turn on the alert groups you care about — Initial Balance extremes, 50% levels, 100% levels — and pick a sound for each.

[SCREENSHOT PLACEHOLDER] An intraday futures chart with the Session Imbalance indicator plotting Initial Balance High, Low and Mid lines for the first 60 minutes, with 50% and 100% extension levels visible above and below
`session-imbalance-initial-balance-chart.png`

How to read it

The Initial Balance is the market's opening auction range. Price holding inside it signals a balanced, rotational session where fading the extremes is the classic play. A clean break and hold beyond the IB High or IB Low signals range extension — a directional session — and the 50% and 100% extensions become natural targets: the 100% extension is a full projection of the opening range beyond the broken side.

The **Mid** line matters intraday too: it often acts as the pivot between the buyers' and sellers' halves of the opening range, and reactions there tell you which side is in control.

Settings reference

General

Setting	What it does
Number of Minutes	Duration of the period used to calculate the session imbalance. Default: 60 minutes (the classic Initial Balance).
Custom Start Time	When enabled, lets you set your own start time; when disabled, the calculation begins at the session open (for U.S. futures, 00:00 Central European Time).
Number of Days (0 - All)	How many sessions to display. 0 shows all available sessions.

Plot Settings

Setting	What it does
High Color / Low Color / Mid Color	Colors of the three primary lines.
Line Width	Thickness of the plotted lines.
Line Style	Solid, Dashed, Dotted and other styles.
Text Size / Text Alignment	Size and placement of the level labels.

Extension Levels

Setting	What it does
50% Extensions	Toggles the 50% extension levels, with a dedicated color selection.
100% Extensions	Toggles the 100% extension levels, with a separate color selection.

Alerts

Three alert categories, each with popup and sound options and a selectable sound type:

- **HH/LL Alerts** — fire when price takes out the Initial Balance extremes.
- **50% Level Alerts** — fire at the 50% extension thresholds.
- **100% Level Alerts** — fire at the 100% extension thresholds.

[SCREENSHOT PLACEHOLDER] The Session Imbalance settings dialog showing the General group with Number of Minutes set to 60, Custom Start Time and Number of Days fields `session-imbalance-settings-dialog.png`

Tips and common mistakes

- **Verify the start time against your instrument.** If your market's session open does not match the default, enable **Custom Start Time** and set it explicitly — an Initial Balance measured from the wrong open is worse than none.
- **Do not treat every extension touch as a reversal.** On strong trend days price can run through the 50% level and tag the 100% extension; read the levels together with the day's structure.
- **Limit the days displayed.** **Number of Days** at 0 loads every session, which is useful for studies but heavy for live trading charts.
- **Use the alerts instead of watching lines.** The three alert groups cover the meaningful events; let them do the monitoring.

Related articles

- Understanding Auction Theory: Imbalance, Unfinished Auctions, Absorption
- Understanding Market Structure and Sessions (RTH/ETH, Rollover)

- Market Profile (TPO)
- Session Marker
- Different Types of Input Data for Indicators
- How to Change the Layout of Indicators